If you're a consumer of Indian OTT content, chances are that Guddu Pandit has become an intrinsic part of your mind palace. The character's arc has catapulted across three seasons of *Mirzapur*—now endearing, now explosive, his actions now understandable, now reprehensible. When actor Ali Fazal first took on the role in the gritty crime drama created for Amazon Prime Video, he admits he already had an inkling that it would be this successful.

After igniting the nation's imagination when it first released in 2018, and acquiring cult status with S2 in 2020, it's unsurprising that *Mirzapur*'s much-awaited S3 became the most-watched show in India during its launch weekend in early July 2024. The four years' wait did not dull the keenness of viewers.

What's the reason behind the runaway success of this *Game of Thrones* style show set in India's northern hinterland? According to Fazal, it's "the sheer characters and the story, grassroots-level stuff". He says, "If you remove the violence from it, then these are issues that a lot of families face...daddy traumas, loss, relationships. We've just used these tropes in a fictionalised world but otherwise they are basic issues. Kids who want to study and become IAS officers, who desperately want to make a name for themselves, who want to become responsible and take care of their families...Family is everything, it's all there."

For Guddu Pandit, though, family is a chimera he has been chasing since the beginning. Fazal provides some context, "In this generation, we are constantly hiding things, there are multiple conversations happening inside our heads, but the real conversations are not happening. I kept a bit of that in mind when getting into Guddu's skin. This person becomes lonely....That base that you need in your life, that one anchor point, is not there. Even his enemies, who were his anchoring points at some point, he's lost." The actor found it diverse and enriching to be able to focus on so many colours in this one lifetime of one character, to essay what he calls "the slow deterioration of the mind".

Fazal explains, "Playing the same character can get challenging or even boring, but the makers made sure to create a world where I could bring in my ideas, collaborate with director Gurmmeet (Singh) on so many things. We could make something meaningful out of Guddu. Otherwise, it's a plain character...people would have been happy with the sheer brawn and how he's beating everyone up. That is easy. We love our bad guys, of course, but there's so much more to the human experience than just that."

A versatile actor, Fazal has held his own opposite international stars of the calibre of Judi Dench (*Victoria & Abdul*) and Gal Gadot (*Death on the Nile*), while playing softer, more urbane characters.

Even as Season 4 of *Mirzapur* is in the works, Fazal has many other exciting projects on the way. He's just wrapped up Anurag Basu's multi-starrer anthology *Metro In Dino*, is understandably thrilled about shooting with Mani Ratnam for *Thug Life* (another gangster drama), and believes that Rajkumar Santoshi's *Lahore 1947* has a wonderful subject and an important story to tell. A few other films in India and one more in the West after *Kandahar* with Gerard Butler await the go-ahead before he opens up fully about them.

Fazal is certainly getting noticed. "People do react differently now, but that's by dint of the nature of the work that I'm doing... that I'm putting out there now and, in the future, both inside and outside India. I'm very grateful for these opportunities and I suppose the optics have worked in my favour," he agrees, adding, "People get fascinated. But it's the same me. And there's always hunger for something else that I want to do. I want to keep finding new stories to tell, new narratives, and surprising myself more than anybody else first."

After the 'violence is my USP' roles in recent times, Fazal craves to be part of a love story. "I want to do a simple romantic drama, one that doesn't try too hard to push the adrenaline rush, for once. Just the basic dramas, like we used to have," he says. "These days, every film pivots on a particular point, and wants to leave you with a lesson at the end. But that is not necessary. I don't want to be your conscience. I don't have to answer your questions. I want to raise questions. In fact, our stories must do that at all times."

Perhaps his most meaningful role yet will be fatherhood. He and Richa welcomed a baby girl on July 16. "I'm really glad about where we are in life, and very thankful to God," says Fazal, with his trademark disarming grin. ■

–Priya Pathiyan

FAZAL IS ALSO INVOLVED IN PROJECTS LIKE ANURAG BASU'S METRO IN DINO, MANI RATNAM'S THUG LIFE AND RAJKUMAR SANTOSHI'S LAHORE 1947

